

**VICTORIOUS
LANKAN TROOPS
IN MULLAITIVU**



AP PHOTO/GEMUNU AMARASINGHE

The ENDGAME

With the Tigers' last bastion falling, the concern shifts to the plight of Tamil civilians

| By Christine Jayasinghe in Colombo |

President Mahinda Rajapakse has reason to be pleased with himself over the outcome of his Government's all out war against the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). After two years of sustained fighting in the island's north despite international pressure to pursue peace talks, the Sri Lanka military has the LTTE on the run in the north-eastern jungles of their last stronghold, Mullaitivu. Army Chief Lieutenant-General Sarath Fonseka said his troops had taken almost a

year to cover a 40-km stretch through jungle terrain to capture Mullaitivu, a base the army lost to the Tigers in 1996 and the nerve centre of the LTTE's Sea Tiger naval operations. The last bastion fell on January 25 after the troops crept up on the Tigers in boats, evading the elaborate barricades that the rebels had erected around Mullaitivu. Earlier, on January 2, Kilinochchi, the LTTE's political and administrative capital from which it ran a bank, courts of justice and police force, was overrun

by government troops.

Rajapakse's relentless campaign has seen the LTTE confined to a 30-km stretch of coastline as compared to a vast swathe of land covering one-third of Sri Lankan territory just two years ago. Government ministers are promising that by February 4, Independence Day, every inch of the island will be under the Government's control. The Tigers resurfaced after big defeats in the 1990s and recaptured lost territory, but analysts believe the military's increased man-